

Translation Loss Game Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-30 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	translation-loss-game

Big idea: Language carries cultural categories.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students explore how language carries cultural concepts.

Student Prompt

Inspect Translation Loss Game Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Translation Loss Game Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Translation Loss Game Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Words such as 'fair', 'home', 'respect', 'awkward', and 'saving face'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Translation Loss Game Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A ranking of what survives translation: fact, tone, value, or worldview. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Language carries cultural categories.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Translation Loss Game Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Translation Loss Game Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can all knowledge be translated?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how language carries cultural categories.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Can all knowledge be translated?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- A phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally.
- Words such as 'fair', 'home', 'respect', 'awkward', and 'saving face'.
- A ranking of what survives translation: fact, tone, value, or worldview.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/translation-loss-game/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/translation-loss-game/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/translation-loss-game/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Groups attempt literal translations or definitions.
2. They then write a cultural explanation or example situation.
3. Groups identify what cannot be captured in one word.
4. Discuss whether translation transfers knowledge or recreates it.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Can all knowledge be translated?

- Does language limit thought or simply influence it?
- What is lost when knowledge moves between languages?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...